THE LAST ROLL

A short film screenplay

A quiet story about memory, change and ordinary time

FADE IN:

INT. GARAGE - LATE AFTERNOON

A half-open garage. Dust hangs in a stripe of sunlight. Boxes are stacked against one wall, some labelled in faded marker. A radio plays quietly from somewhere inside the house.

LEO (17) sits on an overturned bucket, sorting through a box of old things. He is meant to be clearing space. Most of it is rubbish: tangled cables, instruction manuals, a cracked mug.

At the bottom of the box, he finds a small film camera. He turns it over in his hands. A strip of masking tape on the back has a date written on it, years ago.

He presses the shutter. Nothing happens.

He opens the back carefully. There is a roll of film inside.

INT. KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER

Leo places the camera on the table. His mum is putting away groceries.

LEO
Whose is this?

MUM
Your grandad's, I think. He used to take it everywhere.

She glances at it, then carries on unpacking the bags.

Leo looks at the camera again. He takes it with him.

INT. LIVING ROOM - EARLY EVENING

Leo searches a cupboard for batteries, though the camera doesn't need them. He finds a stack of photo albums instead.

He opens one on the floor.

There are pictures of people he barely recognises. A birthday table. A beach crowded with towels. His mum, much younger, holding a paper plate. His grandad standing beside a car with its bonnet open.

Leo turns the pages slowly. The photos are slightly blurred, sometimes badly framed. In one, everyone is looking in different directions. In another, someone's finger covers the corner of the lens.

He stops at a picture of a backyard barbecue. His grandad is in the background, laughing at something outside the frame.

Leo studies it for a moment.

EXT. BACKYARD - EVENING

Leo steps outside with the camera. The yard is overgrown around the edges. A plastic chair leans against the fence. The old clothesline still stands, though one of its arms hangs lower than the other.

He looks around as if trying to match the place to the photographs.

A neighbour's sprinkler clicks on. Water catches the last of the light. A blackbird lands on the fence, looks at Leo, then flies off.

Leo raises the camera and takes a picture of the empty chair.

He waits for something to happen. Nothing does.

He lowers the camera and looks at the chair again.

INT. HOUSE - LATER

Leo finds his mum sitting at the table with a cup of tea. He places the album in front of her and points to the barbecue photo.

LEO
Do you remember this?

His mum leans closer. A small smile, almost involuntary.

MUM
Yeah. That was a good day.

She tells him something about the photo, but we don't hear all of it. Leo listens. He hasn't heard the story before.

When she finishes, she turns the page and points out another picture.

INT. GARAGE - NIGHT

The box is still open. Leo puts the albums back on the shelf, but keeps the camera.

He clears a small space on the workbench. The old camera sits there beside a screwdriver and a jar of loose screws.

From inside the house, his mum calls that dinner is ready.

Leo looks at the camera once more, then switches off the garage light.

INT. KITCHEN - NIGHT

Leo comes in and takes his usual seat. His mum is already eating. They talk about something ordinary. A school notice. A broken tap. What they need from the shops.

Halfway through, Leo asks another question about the old photographs. His mum thinks for a second, then starts telling him.

The camera remains on the workbench in the dark garage.

The kitchen light is warm. The conversation carries on after the plates are cleared.

FADE OUT.

THE END